ZHAO, WANGYIN
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ACADEMIC POSITION

New York University Abu Dhabi, UAE Sep 2026 -
Research Associate/Assistant Research Scientist

EDUCATION

Durham University, Durham, UK Oct 2022 – May 2026
ESRC-Funded PhD Candidate in Politics
Thesis: Natural Disasters and Conflict Dynamics
Supervisors: Dr. Anouk S. Rigterink and Prof. Patrick M Kuhn
Postgraduate Certificate in Research Methods (Sep 2022 – Sep 2023)

Princeton University, Princeton, USA Sep 2025 – Dec 2025
Doctoral fellow at Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC)

London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE), London, UK Oct 2021 – Sep 2022
MSc International Relations (Research)

The University of Nottingham Ningbo China (UNNC), Ningbo, China Sep 2017 – Jun 2021
BA (Hons) International Studies

- With one year abroad at Brunel University London (Oct 2019 – Jun 2020)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Micro-level conflict dynamics of civil war and armed group's strategic behaviour; Exogenous shocks and conflict escalation; Quantitative conflict analysis; Spatial analysis, GIS, and remote sensing; Causal inference

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATION

Zhao, W. (2025), "The Impact of Natural Disasters on the Ongoing Civil War: the Role of Spatial Configuration of Territorial Control", *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 70, No. 2-3, available: https://doi.org/10.1177/00220027251346912

WORKING PAPER

Buying Stability After Sudden and Negative Shocks: How Extractive Companies Dampen Post-Disaster Conflict

- Presents at NERD Workshop, 2025 UCL Conflict & Change Workshop, and 2025 EPSA Conference
- Under Review (*Journal of Peace Research*)

Anticipation, Commitment Problems and Civil War Violence: Evidence from Normal vs. Flash Droughts (with Mahmoud Osman)

- Presented at Political Economy Graduate Workshop and ESOC lab meeting, Princeton University
- Under Review (*American Political Science Review*)

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Logging Policy, Forest Cover, and Insurgent Violence in Afghanistan (with Christopher Blair)

- District-level panel data constructed; analysis in progress

Rain, Terrain, and Insurgent Activity: Evidence from Operation Popeye and the Vietnam War

- Panel data constructed; analysis in progress

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

UG Seminar: **Research Politics and International Relations** (TA), Durham University Oct 2023 – March 2025

UG Seminar: **Introduction to Comparative Politics** (TA), Durham University — Oct 2024 – March 2025

Computer Lab: **Research Politics and International Relations** (TA), Durham University — Jan 2026 – March 2026

CONFERENCES & PRESENTATIONS

Conference Presentations

European Political Science Association (EPSA) Annual Conference, Madrid	Jul 2025
Conflict Research Society (CRS) Annual Conference, Edinburgh	Sep 2024
European Political Science Association (EPSA) Annual Conference, Köln	Aug 2024

Workshops and Internal Presentations

Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC) Lab Meeting, Princeton University (Online)	Mar 2026
Northeast Research Development (NERD) workshop at Durham and Newcastle	Feb 2026
2025 Political Economy Graduate Workshop, Princeton University	Oct 2025
Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC) Lab Meeting, Princeton University (Online)	Feb 2025
2025 UCL Conflict & Change Workshop, London	Feb 2025
Northeast Research Development (NERD) workshop at Durham and Newcastle	Nov 2024
2024 UCL Conflict & Change Workshop, London	Mar 2024
Northeast Research Development (NERD) workshop at Durham and Newcastle	Nov 2023

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

Essex Summer School in **Machine Learning for Social Scientists**	Aug 2024
PhD course on **GIS and the Geography of Armed Conflict** by NTNU and PRIO	Jun 2023
Oxford Spring School in Advanced Research Methods (**Causal Inference**)	Apr 2023
ECPR Virtual Summer School in **Panel Data Analysis**	Jul 2022
Essex Summer School in **Introduction to Quantitative Methods in R**	Jul 2020
Essex Summer School in **Introduction to GIS, Geospatial Data and Spatial Analysis**	Jul 2020
Peking University Summer School in Research on **Quantitative History**	Jul 2019

GRANTS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

ESRC NINE Doctoral Training Partnership Studentship	Oct 2022 – Jun 2026
ESRC NINE DTP Funding for Overseas Institutional Visits	Sep 2025 – Dec 2025
ESRC NINE DTP Research Training Support Grant	2023, 24
Durham University School of Government and International Affairs PGR funding	2023, 24, 25
Durham University Centre of Institution and Political Behaviour Research Funds	2022, 23, 24
Ustinov College Travel Awards (Durham University)	2024, 25
Presidents' Scholarship, UNNC	2020
Zhejiang Province Scholarship	2020
Zhejiang Exchange Scholarship	2020
Head Scholarship, UNNC 2018	2019

AWARDS

Top Student Award for BA (Hons) in International Studies, UNNC	2021
Zhejiang Provincial Excellent Graduates	2021
The Best Student of Year, UNNC	2020
Outstanding Student Leader, UNNC	2020
Silver Award (Brunel Volunteers Award)	2020

OTHER PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

The International Social Science Review Journal (by John Wiley & Sons, Ltd) — May 2022 – Nov 2022
Managing Editor

Research Assistant — Jul 2022 – Nov 2022
ESRC-Funded project – Nonviolent Repression and the Escalation of Conflicts over Self-Determination (NRECS) by Dr. Micha Germann, Bath University

Research Assistant Jul 2021
Work on the research by Dr. Joy Spiliopoulos, UNNC, about the Filipino nurse migration and return migration, and immigration policies in destination countries, namely the UK and Southeast Asia

The Institute of Asia and Pacific Studies, UNNC Jun 2020 – Jun 2021
Research Intern for research projects of the Cultural and Creative Industries

JOURNAL REFEREE

Journal of Conflict Resolution (2025) and *Conflict Management and Peace Science* (2025)

SKILLS

Software: R, GeoDa, ArcGIS, QGIS (, with Python/PyQ), Google Earth Engine (, with JavaScript), NVivo, LaTeX
Language: Mandarin Chinese (Native), English (Fluent)

REFERENCES

Patrick M. Kuhn
Senior Program Manager
Einstein School of Public Policy, ETH Zurich
Formerly Professor, Durham University
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School of Government and International Affairs
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